

Crème caramel

I'm not against traditionally made desserts (actually, I'm usually all for them), but for some crazy reason I wanted to challenge myself to see if I could make a crème caramel as creamy and **luscious** as the original but made without eggs and white sugar. I got a lot of enjoyment out of creating and re-creating this dish, trying to get it just right. As I've said, many vegan desserts are a disappointment to me, but I think this one is a winner.

Vegetable cooking spray

$\frac{3}{4}$ cup light-colored unrefined cane sugar
[150g]

Pinch of salt

4 teaspoons egg replacer powder (look for Ener-G brand)

1 tablespoon arrowroot

$1\frac{1}{2}$ cups vanilla soy milk [375g]

1 pound extra-firm silken tofu [500g]

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup maple syrup [125g]

$1\frac{1}{2}$ tablespoons Kahlúa*

1. **Preheat** the oven to 350°F [175°C]. Prepare eight 6-ounce [180-g] custard cups or ovenproof ramekins by coating them lightly with cooking spray.
2. Put the sugar in a small heavy saucepan, then add $\frac{1}{4}$ cup [60ml] water. Bring to a boil over medium heat without stirring, gently swirling the pan by the handle until a syrup begins to form. **Cover** and cook for 2 minutes. Uncover and continue to boil until the sugar is thick and dark amber, another 2 or 3 minutes.
3. Quickly and carefully, **pour** the caramel into the custard cups, tilting to make sure the bottoms are completely covered.
4. In a medium bowl, combine the egg replacer, arrowroot, and $\frac{1}{4}$ cup [60ml] of the milk. **Whisk** until very smooth. Add the remaining milk and blend well.

*Look for the mini bottles in the liquor store if you don't want to buy a whole bottle.

5. In a blender or food processor, **puree** the tofu until very smooth, at least 1 minute. Add the soy milk mixture, maple syrup, and Kahlúa. Blend until very smooth.
6. **Pour** the tofu mixture into the prepared cups and place them in a larger baking dish or roasting pan. Fill the larger pan with enough warm water to reach one third up the sides of the cups.
7. Bake for 40 minutes, or until the crème caramel is firm to the touch but still slightly jiggly in the center. Let cool, then **refrigerate** for at least 2 hours or overnight. Before serving, loosen the sides of the crème caramels with a sharp paring knife. Place a plate, serving side down, over each cup and invert quickly to unmold. Serve immediately.

MAKES 8 PORTIONS, 1/2 CUP [125ML] EACH

